SONIC ART: SHIFTING PARADIGMS IN ECOLOGICAL CRISIS

Leah Barclay
PhD Candidate, Queensland Conservatorium of Music,
Griffith University, Australia
info@leahbarclay.com | www.leahbarclay.com

ABSTRACT

Today's global ecological crisis challenges creative practitioners to devise new processes that can contribute to cultural change. There is an urgent need to listen to our environment and reconnect remnants of self, culture and place. 'Sound' is undoubtedly one of the most powerful means to stimulate this shift in consciousness.

The dramatic advancement of digital media and information technology has truly cultivated a paradigm shift in how we collaborate as artists today. These changes have evolved and expanded the tools of expression but most importantly they have opened the ability to communicate at a higher level in an interdisciplinary context. Sonic art is integral to this process and has a profound ability to ignite an awareness and connection to the environment.

This research seeks to identify the role of sonic art in the current ecological emergency through a series of case studies and experiments. Sonic art, particularly acousmatic music, is a powerful medium to inspire change, but can this genre extend beyond purely expression? What are the implications of organic soundscapes designed to stimulate growth and converse with ecosystems? What issues arise when ritual sounds of the pasts are recontextualised and augmented with technology?

This paper presents case studies outlining the impact of three contrasting projects recently implemented in regional Australia and New Zealand. These include; *Sonic Babylon*, a global project planting interactive gardens of sound; *Blue Gold*, a hybrid performance installation by Ros Bandt exploring water as the commodity of the 21st Century, and the sonic art initiatives of the Remnant/Emergency Artlab, a team of artists forging new processes targeting the roots of our collective ecological crisis.